

Document 8: Dry Eye Syndrome

Metadata

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Definition of Dry Eye Syndrome

Dry eye syndrome is a common condition that occurs when the eyes do not produce enough tears or when the tears evaporate too quickly. This leads to instability of the tear film, causing inadequate lubrication and inflammation on the surface of the eye.

Symptoms of Dry Eye Syndrome

Symptoms usually affect both eyes and may fluctuate throughout the day. They include:

- A stinging, burning, or scratchy sensation in the eyes
- Stringy mucus in or around the eyes
- Eye redness and a feeling of having something in the eye (foreign body sensation)
- Difficulty wearing contact lenses
- Paradoxical watery eyes (the body's response to the irritation of dry eyes)
- Blurred vision or eye fatigue, especially after looking at screens

Treatment and Management for Dry Eye Syndrome

Management involves adding moisture and reducing tear evaporation:

- **Lubrication:** Frequent use of over-the-counter artificial tears or lubricating eye ointments.
- **Environmental Changes:** Using a humidifier, avoiding blowing air directly into the eyes, and taking frequent screen breaks (the 20-20-20 rule).
- **Eyelid Care:** Applying warm compresses over closed eyes and gently massaging the eyelids to help release oils that prevent tear evaporation.

When to Seek Medical Attention for Dry Eye Syndrome

A patient should see a healthcare provider or ophthalmologist if they experience:

- Prolonged symptoms of dry, red, or painful eyes that do not respond to artificial tears.
- Flaking or crusting of the eyelids (which may indicate blepharitis).
- A sudden decrease in vision or a noticeable change in eye health.